



a symbol of national resilience; she rallied her beleaguered people and supported reforms to strengthen the military. She died in 1810, and the Order of Louise (Luisen-Orden) was founded in her honor in 1814 to recognize women's distinguished service to Prussia, regardless of their social class.

### Patriotic women

Across Europe, women followed Louise's example and took part in nationalist anti-Napoleonic activism. Societal norms meant they did so primarily along traditional gender lines, separately from men, for example by caring for the wounded, sewing flags, or preparing supplies for soldiers. They also formed women's patriotic associations (there

### ◀ The Maid of Saragossa

Agustina de Aragón fought the French during the siege of Zaragoza. She was imprisoned when the French seized the city, but escaped and became a guerrilla leader, as well as a symbol of Spanish resistance.

were over 600 in the German lands alone) to collect money and organize charitable efforts. Women were lauded as heroines for their patriotism during the wars, as long as they expressed this within the boundaries of accepted female behavior, and did not take up arms, which was regarded as a male activity.

Yet not all women stayed within this docile realm of feminine patriotism. Some of the fiercest responses to Napoleonic rule came from female Spanish guerrillas, such as Agustina of Aragón, who single-handedly manned the defenses of Zaragoza in 1808. As in the French Revolutionary Wars (see pp. 130–133) thousands of women joined armies in the battlefield as camp followers, and some served as soldiers, disguising their gender. The most celebrated female soldier was Nadezhda Durova, who joined a Russian cavalry regiment disguised as a boy in 1807 and distinguished herself for her valor in battle. Durova was not dismissed when her gender was discovered; rather Czar Alexander I gave her a medal and promotion, and she served until 1816. Other women who fought were not so lucky—many were punished while alive and only glorified as national heroines after their deaths.

**"MY MOTHER ... DID EVERYTHING ... [TO] [INCREASE MY] PASSION FOR ... MILITARY LIFE."**

NADEZHDA DUROVA, (1783–1866) *THE CAVALRY MAIDEN: JOURNALS OF A RUSSIAN OFFICER IN THE NAPOLEONIC WARS*

